



These days, buying a smartphone is not just about what features the phone offers, but also about what OS it's running

how stressful your usage pattern will be. These days, any Android phone that gives a battery backup of a day and a half is considered very good, and a day on a single charge is pretty much standard.

Storage

With the ever increasing app sizes and everyone clicking pictures and shooting videos, storage has a way of filling up fast. There are two distinct categories of phones out there, some have loads of internal storage space, but no expansion slot, and those that offer expansion. You need to find the balance, and think about how much space you'll need. By rule of thumb, sit down and calculate space based on your usage, and then double the storage (minimum) you think you need.

Operating system

The market is flooded with phones with a variety of OSes – Android Gingerbread, Android Ice Cream Sandwich, Android Jelly Bean, Apple's iOS6, Windows Phone, Blackberry OS and Symbian Belle. These OSes are available on phones spread

across a variety of price points. However, variety is all well and good, but you need to make a serious decision about which one suits you best depending on the comfort level, and the features you may need. Each OS has its unique interface and user experience aspects, and it's very critical that it's exactly what you need. Also, if apps matter to you, do some homework and see whether your favourite apps are available on the platform/OS you are considering. Variety on the app stores does sway a lot of decisions, and you should consider the importance of the same. We suggest you don't fall for the glitter of a particular smartphone, before considering the software you will be interfacing with.

Service and support

This is a non-quantifiable aspect of buying a smartphone. We have no comparison

tests to prove that the service of brand X is better than brand Y. It all depends on the type of problem with the device, and factors like the service centre location, attitude of the staff and even the availability of spares if needed. However, if you have been hearing bad feedback about a particular brand from friends and acquaintances, and the same results are mirrored online, it's better to stay away from such a brand. After all, a lot of people couldn't be wrong all the time.

Camera

This comes so far down this list because we believe it's relevant only to someone who needs the phone's camera quite often. Don't go by just the specs and megapixels, take test shots in good lighting conditions and also in not very brightly lit room. This will give you a fair idea of what the performance will be like. We have seen 8MP cameras on phones perform much better than 12MP cameras on other phones.

This should not matter...

Equally, we have a bunch of seemingly very critical things that should ideally not matter as much.

Quad-core processors

On paper, more cores may mean more fun bragging about your new phone at the next party. However, in terms of real life usage, we believe that the experience is what matters more. If you have a dual core phone equally capable of giving you a smooth and stable performance, why the need for more cores? Furthermore, there still aren't too many apps that will utilise the full capabilities of a quad-core processor.

DECISION TIME SMARTPHONE

There never really is a perfect time to buy any gadget, let alone a smartphone. Buy a flagship device today, and the successor will hit the stores within the next 6 to 8 months. And most likely with a slightly higher price tag. Unless you want to be a part of that vicious circle, you will be better off not thinking about what's new, and being smart and considering what suits you best. Also, keep some hardware headroom in terms of future proofing. Usually, no matter what price you may have in mind, you will get a considerable upgrade (hardware or software, either one) within another ₹2,500 to ₹3,500. But do buy smart, because it is the experience that matters when using the phone day in and day out, and not what it said on the spec sheet before you purchase it.

ASUS Optical Drive

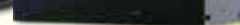
A Green Environment for now and the Future



- E-Green Engine Technology automatically optimizes drives' power consumption.
- E-Green displays detailed information on power saved and CO₂ reduced by using the ASUS drive.



SDRW-08D2S-U LITE
External Slim DVD Drive



DRW-24B5ST
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